totalitarian institutions? And doesn't this undermine the thesis that totalitarianism was made possible only by modern information technology?

There are, however, several major differences between modern totalitarianism and pre-modern churches. First, as noted earlier, modern totalitarianism has worked by deploying several overlapping surveillance mechanisms that keep one another in order. The party is never alone; it works alongside state organs, on the one side, and the secret police, on the other. In contrast, in most medieval European kingdoms the Catholic Church was an independent institution that often clashed with the state institutions instead of reinforcing them. Consequently, the church was perhaps the most important check on the power of European autocrats.

For example, when in the 'Investiture Controversy' of the 1070s King Henry IV of Germany and Italy asserted that he had the final say on the appointment of bishops, abbots and other church officials, Pope Gregory VII mobilised resistance and eventually forced the king to surrender. On 25 January 1077, Henry reached Canossa castle, where the pope was lodging, to offer his submission and apology. The pope refused to open the gates, and Henry waited in the snow outside, barefoot and hungry. After three days, the pope finally opened the gates to the king, who begged forgiveness.[104]

An analogous clash in a modern totalitarian country is unthinkable. The whole idea of totalitarianism is to prevent any separation of powers. In the Soviet Union, state and party reinforced each other, and Stalin was the de facto head of both. There could be no Soviet 'Investiture Controversy', because Stalin had final say about all appointments to both party positions and state functions. He decided both who would be general secretary of the Communist Party of Georgia and who would be foreign minister of the Soviet Union.

Another important difference is that medieval churches tended to be traditionalist organisations that resisted change, while modern totalitarian parties have tended to be revolutionary organisations demanding change. A pre-modern church built its power gradually by developing its structure and traditions over centuries. A king or a pope who wanted to swiftly revolutionise society was therefore likely to encounter stiff resistance from church members and ordinary believers.

For example, in the eighth and ninth centuries a series of Byzantine emperors sought to forbid the veneration of icons, which seemed to them